

extremely responsive in high-volume environments. Also, there are many high-quality GUI tools available for PostgreSQL, from both open source developers and commercial providers.”

PostgreSQL has features comparable to proprietary database management systems, and is known for greater reliability, performance and scalability in comparison with most databases. “It has a core transactional ability like ACID properties and deadlock functions. It has many essential features for business applications like BLOBS, triggers, functions and views. This gives the systems administration team a high level of control over performance tuning and management. All the solutions implemented on this database-management system have delivered optimum performance. It offers more opportunity for performance fine-tuning than proprietary databases.

“PostgreSQL is light-weight and handy, and at the same time, it offers extreme performance for heavy-duty applications. Its availability is also at par with better-known proprietary DBMSs. This is ideal for cluster computing and high-availability cluster integration. It has been designed to ensure much lower maintenance and tuning requirements than the leading proprietary databases, yet retains all of the features, stability, and performance. Unlike many proprietary databases, it is extremely common for companies to report that PostgreSQL has never crashed for them in spite of several years of high-activity operations. Moreover, the source code is available at no charge. It is possible to customise and extend PostgreSQL with minimum effort, and with no attached costs,” Kumar feels. A vibrant community of PostgreSQL professionals and enthusiasts around the globe contributes ideas on a daily basis, ensuring this benefit.

Other PostgreSQL solutions that Focuz Infotech has developed are: Web-based campus automation software at NIT (Durgapur); Web-based campus automation software at St Aloysius Deemed University (Jabalpur); and client/server-based automation software for ICAR units like IISR (Calicut), NBPGR (Delhi), CARI (Andaman) and IIHR (Bangalore).

Vast open source experience

Focuz Infotech also realised that using FOSS reduces the number of threats faced by customers. “We develop all our products under the GNU/Linux platform, after considering its scalability, reliability and security. We have deployed solutions for reputed clients from both public and private sectors, and provide post-implementation solutions and support on a 24/7 basis,” Kumar explains. Focuz

Infotech handles issues like storage, mission-critical distributed computing, network security, corporate communications, IP VPN connectivity, campus automation, media management, Linux thin clients, clustering, Linux migration assistance, remote server support, Linux embedded solutions and application development, including Linux-based ERPs and process-control software.

But there are hurdles too...

Though Focuz Infotech was thoroughly impressed with PostgreSQL, the team had to deal with some issues in the initial stages. “Our first challenge was performance, memory management and cluster implementation. During the implementation of a B2B solution for Focuz Group, an average of 400 users needed to work concurrently. During the initial phase, we noticed more live connections than we expected, and this led to slow software access at the user level. We also encountered an issue while allocating more memory to the database, as it did not give us the expected results. These issues were later sorted out by database fine-tuning,” says Kumar.

Moreover, customers are not always excited about deploying open source applications, and some may require more convincing. Kumar illustrates, “A few were reluctant and defensive about using open source, as they feel Linux is not user-friendly, or that there is technical complexity during migration, and a lack of support. We reassured them that we have our own R&D lab to manage our open source solutions, and most problems are solved within Focuz Infotech. We have also tied up with Novell and IBM, and take help from them in case we need support for SuSE Linux and IBM hardware. Now, clients’ concerns about Linux-based solutions have vanished. Customers who approach us are eager to learn more about Linux-based applications and their reliability, prior to deciding on implementing a solution.”

Going forward

Focuz Infotech is in the process of completing 12 government projects connected with e-governance, and over 20 private projects that require stand-alone products. “While there are many seeking open source solutions today, we trust the sky to become yet more clear and open!” concludes Kumar. 

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The author is a journalist at the EFY Group. She is a fan of anything portable, and loves exploring different genres of music and movies.